

Diwan-i-Aam (Hall of Public Audience)

ديوان عام

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Emperor Shah Jahan (original); an upper balcony reportedly added by Akbar; the structure standing today is a British-era reconstruction
- Built in: 1631 CE (original construction)
- Cost: Not documented in available sources
- Built for: The emperor's daily public appearances, formal audiences with visitors, and review of parades

2. Construction Details

- Design concept: A forty-pillar public audience hall, modelled on the Persian Chehel Sotoun ("forty columns") hall tradition
- Materials: Not separately documented for the reconstructed British-era version versus the lost Mughal original
- Craftsmen involved: Not documented
- Time taken: Not documented

3. Historical Background

- Heavily damaged and effectively destroyed in 1841, when Sher Singh bombarded the fort during his power struggle with Chand Kaur amid the chaotic Sikh succession crisis following Ranjit Singh's death.
- The hall was rebuilt during British rule - meaning the Diwan-i-Aam visitors see today is a 19th-century British-era reconstruction rather than the original Shah Jahan-period structure, a detail often glossed over in casual accounts of the fort.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- The Chehel Sotoun (forty-pillar hall) concept the Diwan-i-Aam is modelled on comes directly from Persian royal architecture, one of the clearest examples of direct Persian influence anywhere in the fort.
- The building's violent 1841 destruction happened entirely within a single Sikh royal family's internal power struggle - not a foreign invasion.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Picture the hall in its Mughal prime: forty columns holding up a canopy of shade while the emperor, seated above the crowd, receives petitioners one by one. Two centuries later, that same courtyard fills with smoke and falling masonry as one Sikh claimant to the throne bombards it to dislodge another - and the "original" hall you can walk through today is, in fact, the British Empire's careful rebuild of what that single day of violence destroyed.

AI Heritage Revive — Lahore Fort landmark reference. Compiled from encyclopedic research report; figures marked "Not documented" are intentionally left blank rather than estimated.